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8.9 Answer Explanations: Critical Reasoning

The following discussion is intended to familiarize you with the most efficient and effective approaches to Critical Reasoning questions. The particular questions in this chapter are generally representative of the kinds of Critical Reasoning questions you will encounter on the GMAT exam. Remember that it is the problem-solving strategy that is important, not the specific details of a particular question.

Questions 613–672 — Difficulty: Easy

613. Arts advocate: Few universities require that students who are specializing in science and technology take many art courses. However, real progress in science and technology requires an element of creativity, which the arts foster. Thus, to help science and technology students succeed in their careers, universities should increase the number of art courses required for them.

Which of the following would, if true, most strengthen the argument above?

A. Universities required more art courses for science and technology students in the past.

B. Participation in art courses increases students' creative thinking in their science and technology courses.

C. More students who are interested in art would specialize in science and technology if the number of art courses required for those programs were increased.

D. Some of the most prominent scientists began their careers as artists.

E. Discussion of science and technology topics in art courses increases creative thinking among students in those courses.

Argument Evaluation

Situation The arts advocate argues that universities should increase the number of art courses required for students specializing in science and technology, with the goal of helping these students succeed in their careers. Few universities require students in these fields to take many art courses.

Reasoning *What piece of information, if true and added to the argument, would most strengthen it?* One of the arts advocate's premises is that progress in science and technology requires creativity. Another premise is that courses in the arts foster creativity. The conclusion is that universities should, for the sake of promoting career success, require students specializing in science and technology to take more courses in art. Suppose that participation in art courses enriches students' participation in the science and technology courses: that would be a further reason for universities to require that the students take more art courses.

A. This does not indicate that increasing art offerings now for science and technology students is the most prudent course of action. Universities' past decision to offer fewer art courses for science and technology students may have resulted from review of data, careful analysis, and prudent policy assumptions. For example, the decision may have been required in order to finance provision of more science and technology courses.

B. **Correct.** This suggests that participation in art courses increases the value of science and technology courses, an additional piece of information that strengthens the argument.

C. The argument does not suggest that the goal of requiring science and technology students to take more art courses is to persuade more students interested in art to specialize in science and technology. This information is therefore largely irrelevant to the arts advocate's Reasoning.

D. This information does not address the role art may have played in the scientists' achievements in science and technology. Several of these scientists may well have been aspiring artists who failed or became disenchanted and discovered that they could better exploit their talents in science and technology.

E. The arts advocate does not advocate that science and technology topics be addressed in art courses. The arts advocate's Reasoning focuses on the value of art courses in fostering creativity.

The correct answer is B.

614. Ramirez: The film industry claims that pirated DVDs, which are usually cheaper than legitimate DVDs and

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614. Ramirez: The film industry claims that pirated DVDs, which are usually cheaper than legitimate DVDs and become available well before a film's official DVD release date, adversely affect its bottom line. But the industry should note what the spread of piracy indicates: consumers want lower prices and faster DVD releases. Lowering prices of DVDs and releasing them sooner would mitigate piracy's negative effect on film industry profits.

The argument above relies on which of the following assumptions?

A. Releasing legitimate DVDs earlier would not cause any reduction in the revenue the film industry receives from the films' theatrical release.

B. Some people who would otherwise purchase pirated DVDs would be willing to purchase legitimate DVDs if they were less expensive and released earlier than they are now.

C. The film industry will in the future be able to produce DVDs more cheaply than is currently the case.

D. Some current sellers of pirated DVDs would likely discontinue their businesses if legitimate DVDs were released faster and priced lower.

E. Current purchasers of pirated DVDs are aware that those DVDs are not authorized by the film industry.

Argument Construction

Situation Pirated DVDs of films are released earlier than the film's official DVD release day. They are also sold more cheaply. These practices cut into the revenue expected from a film's official DVD sales. According to Ramirez, the prevalence of piracy indicates that consumers want lower prices and earlier releases. Ramirez concludes that if the official DVDs were sold more cheaply and released earlier, the impact of piracy on film industry profits might be reduced.

Reasoning *What must Ramirez assume for the argument to be logically correct?* To evaluate which answer choice the argument relies on assuming, ask yourself about each answer choice, "If this statement were false, then would the argument's conclusion also have to be false?" If the answer is yes, then the argument must be making that assumption. For example, suppose the statement made in answer choice B were false. That would mean that none of the people who would otherwise purchase pirated DVDs would be willing to purchase legitimate DVDs even if these were released earlier and at a significantly lower price. If that were so, then the measures Ramirez suggests would not mitigate piracy.

A. This does not have to be assumed for Ramirez's reasoning to be logically good. Earlier release of the official DVDs at a lower price could somewhat reduce revenue from movie theater showings of the films. But if the revenue from official DVDs released earlier and priced lower were greatly boosted through greatly increased official DVD sales, overall revenue for each film could be higher than would be the case with widespread piracy.

B. **Correct.** If all existing purchasers of pirated film DVDs continued to purchase such DVDs even after implementation of the changes Ramirez advocates, then the changes would not mitigate the destructive consequences of piracy. Thus, Ramirez's reasoning must assume that the recommended changes would cause at least some former purchasers of pirated DVDs to begin purchasing the official DVDs.

C. This might improve profits provided revenue did not also decline. Ramirez's argument does not depend on the assumption that the cost of producing DVDs will decline. Ramirez's reasoning assumes that total sales volume for official DVDs would increase if piracy were reduced.

D. Ideally, this would occur with the change Ramirez recommends, but it does not have to be assumed for Ramirez's reasoning to be logically sound. For example, the result Ramirez predicts could occur if all existing sellers of pirated DVDs continued to sell them but sold fewer.

E. This is likely true but is not an assumption that Ramirez needs to make for the reasoning to be logically sound. Even if some DVDs sold by DVD sellers were pirated without the sellers being aware of it, e.g., if they purchased them from a fraudulent wholesaler, the fact that the pirated DVDs are sold more cheaply and before the release of the official DVD would reduce the filmmakers' total revenue.

The correct answer is B.

615. Harunia Province has a relatively dry climate and is attracting a fast-growing population that has put increasing demands on its water supply. The two companies that supply water to the region have struggled to keep up with

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demand and still remain profitable. Yet now they are asking Harunian authorities to write residential water-use regulations that could reduce their revenues and restrict their future flexibility in supplying water profitably.

Which of the following would, if true, most logically help explain why the water-supply companies are asking the authorities to regulate residential water use?

A. The companies are planning large water-transportation and irrigation systems that require the approval of neighboring provinces.

B. The companies believe regulation is inevitable and that having it in place now will allow better planning and thus future profitability.

C. Few, if any, Harunian government officials have investments in the companies or serve on their boards of directors.

D. The companies believe that the population is not likely to continue to grow.

E. Long-term climate projections suggest that greater rainfall will eventually increase the amount of water available.

Argument Construction

Situation Two water-supply companies are asking the authorities in Harunia Province to regulate residential water use, even though regulation could reduce their revenues and restrict their flexibility in supplying water profitably in the future.

Reasoning *Which piece of information would most help explain why the companies are advocating water-use regulations that would restrict their operations?* The companies are already struggling to keep up with demand from a fast-growing population in the region. So why would they advocate regulations that could, at least in the immediate term, reduce their profits and restrict them? Is there any advantage that the companies perceive—an advantage that would outweigh any disadvantages—in getting regulations instituted soon?

A. It is unclear how this information bears on the companies' request for regulations in Harunia Province, since neighboring provinces seem primarily involved.

B. **Correct.** The companies presumably must strategically plan their capital investments to cope with increasing water demand in Harunia Province and to receive adequate return on that investment. In that context it seems critically important for the companies to have certainty at the planning stage about future regulatory requirements. Moreover, given possible shortfalls in water supply, the companies would reasonably expect government regulation even if they did not request it.

C. This suggests that, in framing water regulations, Harunian government officials will not be influenced by financial interests, so the companies cannot expect to obtain special favors from the regulatory authorities in the framing of water regulations.

D. If anything, this suggests that the companies could continue to operate without any regulatory regime that might restrict their operations.

E. This would presumably result in a weakening of the case for residential water-use regulation and would also make it easier for the water-supply companies to meet demand.

The correct answer is B.

616. Loss of the Gocha mangrove forests has caused coastal erosion, reducing fish populations and requiring the Gocha Fishing Cooperative (GFC) to partially fund dredging and new shore facilities. However, as part of its subsidiary businesses, the GFC has now invested in a program to replant significant parts of the coast with mangrove trees. Given income from a controlled harvest of wood with continuing replanting, the mangrove regeneration effort makes it more likely that the cooperative will increase its net income.

Which of the following, if true, would most strengthen the argument that mangrove replanting will increase the Gocha cooperative's net income?

A. The cost of dredging and shore facilities was shared with the local government.

B. The GFC will be able to hire local workers to assist with the mangrove replanting.

C. The GFC derives 10 percent of its revenue from salt-production facilities in an area previously cleared of

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C. The GFC derives 10 percent of its revenue from salt-production facilities in an area previously cleared of mangroves.

D. Mangrove forests tend to increase the commercial fish populations in coastal fishing grounds.

E. A controlled harvesting of mangrove wood by the GFC would have little effect on coastal erosion.

Argument Evaluation

Situation A subsidiary business of the Gocha Fishing Cooperative (GFC) has invested in a program to replant significant parts of the coast with mangrove trees.

Reasoning *What additional information, if true, would most strengthen the argument's support for the conclusion that the mangrove regeneration effort will increase the GFC's net income?* If the regeneration effort helped the GFC's fishing operations, this could lead to an increase in GFC's income.

A. If the local government helped with the cost of dredging and shore facilities, that would help reduce the GFC's costs, but that is not directly related to the impact of the GFC's mangrove regeneration effort on GFC's net income.

B. It is unclear whether hiring local workers to assist with mangrove replanting would be less costly than hiring workers from elsewhere, so it is unclear whether this would help the GFC increase its net income.

C. The information provided does not indicate whether the mangrove regeneration effort will have any effect on its salt-production facilities, or any revenue or profit that it derives from these facilities, so this does not strengthen the argument.

D. **Correct.** If the mangrove restoration effort helps increase the commercial fish population in coastal fishing grounds, then there is a good chance that the GFC's income from its fishing operations will increase as a result.

E. The information provided does not indicate what, if any, effect coastal erosion has on GFC's net income, so the fact that controlled harvesting of mangrove wood would have little effect on coastal erosion does not strengthen the argument.

The correct answer is D.

617. Executives at the Fizzles Beverage Company plan to boost profits in Country X on their range of fruit-flavored drinks by introducing new flavors based on tropical fruits that are little known there. The executives reason that since the fruit drinks of other companies have none of these flavors, Fizzles will not have to compete for customers and thus will be able to sell the drinks at a higher price.

Which of the following, if true, presents the most serious potential weakness of the plan?

A. The new fruit drinks would be priced significantly higher than other Fizzles fruit drinks with more conventional flavors.

B. In a telephone survey, at least one of the consumers contacted said that they preferred many of the new flavors to all of the more familiar flavors.

C. To build widespread demand for the new flavors, Fizzles would have to launch an advertising campaign to familiarize consumers with them.

D. Consumers choosing among fruit-flavored drinks of different brands generally buy on the basis of name recognition and price rather than the specific fruit flavor.

E. Few consumers who are loyal to a specific brand of fruit-flavored drinks would willingly switch to another brand that costs more.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation Fizzle Beverage Company's executives plan to offer drinks with tropical fruit flavors that are little known in Country X in the hope that doing so will boost profits in that country. They reason that because their competitors in that country do not offer drinks with these flavors, Fizzle will be able to sell the drinks at a premium price.

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Reasoning *What casts the most doubt on the claim that the executives' plan will effectively allow them to sell fruit-flavored drinks at a higher price?* The executives believe that the lack of a direct competitor to these drinks will allow the company to sell the drinks for a higher price. But any information indicating that something other than the specific fruit flavor of the drink drives sales of fruit-flavored drinks would cast doubt on the plan.

A. We have already been told that the prices will be higher. The question is whether they will be able to sell the drink successfully at these higher prices as a result of the plan.

B. This provides at least some very slight support for the belief that the plan would succeed (if no one at all preferred the new drinks, then the plan would almost certainly fail); however, the question asks for something that would cast doubt on the effectiveness of the plan.

C. When introducing a new product, companies usually have to launch advertising campaigns, and quite frequently such campaigns effectively create demand for the product, so the fact that Fizzles will have to launch an advertising campaign does not cast doubt on the plan.

D. **Correct.** The plan depends on consumers wanting the drinks because of their unique, unfamiliar flavors, and being willing to pay a higher price for them because of their uniqueness in the market. If price (presumably a lower one) and name recognition, rather than the specific fruit flavor, are what generally drive sales, then it seems unlikely that the executives' plan will succeed.

E. Nothing in the information provided indicates how many consumers are loyal to any specific brand of fruit-flavored drinks. Perhaps the vast majority of consumers are willing to switch brands. If that is so, then the fact that the very few who are loyal to a specific brand would not be willing to switch would not cast much doubt on the effectiveness of the plan.

The correct answer is D.

618. Economist: In 2015, the average per-person amount paid for goods and services purchased by consumers in Country X was the equivalent of $17,570 in United States dollars, just 30 percent of the corresponding figure of $58,566 for Country Y. Yet in 2015, there was already a substantial middle class in Country X that had discretionary income for middle-class consumer goods such as new vehicles, computers, or major household appliances, while a significant portion of the middle class in Country Y did not have sufficient income to purchase such items.

Which of the following, if true, most helps explain the discrepancy in the relationships described by the economist?

A. There are many consumer goods, such as household appliances, that are produced in Country X to be sold in the Country Y market.

B. The volume of trade between Country X and Country Y is increasing rapidly in both directions.

C. The economy of Country Y is recovering from a downturn that affected both Country Y and Country X.

D. Country X residents pay much less than their Country Y counterparts for housing, transportation, and child care.

E. In Country Y as well as in Country X, there are few assembly-line jobs in factories that pay a middle-class wage.

Argument Construction

Situation An economist points out that even though in 2015 the average per-person amount paid for goods and services in Country X was only 30 percent of the corresponding figure in Country Y, a substantial middle class in Country X had discretionary income for consumer goods, whereas a substantial portion of the middle class in Country Y did not.

Reasoning *What, if true, would most help explain the discrepancies described by the economist?* Information indicating that residents in Country X pay much less for nondiscretionary items than do residents of Country Y would help explain why, even though people in Country Y pay on average three times more for goods and services than people in Country X, Country X has a more substantial middle class capable of buying discretionary goods than does Country Y.

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A. That many consumer goods produced in Country X are intended to be sold in Country Y does not help explain why many people in Country Y are not able to afford such goods.

B. An increasing volume of trade between Country X and Country Y—which, for all we know, is perfectly balanced—would not help explain any discrepancies between the two countries.

C. That the economies of both Country X and Country Y suffered a downturn, and Country Y is recovering, could not plausibly explain why many people in Country Y have trouble paying for discretionary goods unless we had the information that Country Y's recovery was significantly slower than Country X's. But we do not have that information.

D. **Correct.** That people in one nation pay far less for nondiscretionary goods than people in another nation would potentially be helpful in explaining how the people in the former nation would more easily be able to afford discretionary goods.

E. If a claim is true of both Country X and Country Y, it would not help explain a discrepancy between the two countries.

The correct answer is D.

619. Neuroscientist: Memory evolved to help animals react appropriately to situations they encounter by drawing on the past experience of similar situations. But this does not require that animals perfectly recall every detail of all their experiences. Instead, to function well, memory should generalize from past experiences that are similar to the current one.

The neuroscientist's statements, if true, most strongly support which of the following conclusions?

A. At least some animals perfectly recall every detail of at least some past experiences.

B. Perfectly recalling every detail of all their past experiences could help at least some animals react more appropriately than they otherwise would to new situations they encounter.

C. Generalizing from past experiences requires clear memories of most if not all the details of those experiences.

D. Recalling every detail of all past experiences would be incompatible with any ability to generalize from those experiences.

E. Animals can often react more appropriately than they otherwise would to situations they encounter if they draw on generalizations from past experiences of similar situations.

Argument Construction

Situation A neuroscientist claims that memory evolved to help animals learn how to react appropriately by generalizing from past experiences but that this does not require animals to remember all details of those experiences.

Reasoning *What conclusion would the neuroscientist's theory about memory most strongly support?* The neuroscientist asserts that the evolutionary function of memory is to help animals learn to react appropriately by drawing on generalizations from similar experiences they have had. If memory is to serve this function, drawing on generalizations must actually help animals learn to react more appropriately than they otherwise would, even when they do not remember all the details of past experiences.

A. Even if no animal ever recalls all the details of any past experience, animals could still learn through generalizations, as the neuroscientist claims.

B. This statement could be false even if all of what the neuroscientist says is true. Even if it were never helpful for any animal to recall every detail of all its past experiences, animals could still benefit by learning through generalizations.

C. Generalizations from experiences might be made while the experiences are occurring, so that only the generalizations and not the details need to be remembered.

D. The neuroscientist only claims that remembering perfect details is not required for memory to serve its function, not that such perfect recall is incompatible with memory serving its function.

E. **Correct.** If the evolutionary function of memory is to help animals react more appropriately by drawing on

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E. **Correct.** If the evolutionary function of memory is to help animals react more appropriately by drawing on generalizations from past experiences, it follows that animal memories can often successfully serve this function in this manner.

The correct answer is E.

620. In Country X's last election, the Reform Party beat its main opponent, the Conservative Party, although pollsters, employing in-person interviews shortly before the vote, had projected a Conservative Party victory. Afterward, the pollsters determined that, unlike Conservative Party supporters, Reform Party supporters were less likely to express their party preference during in-person interviews than they were during telephone interviews. Therefore, using only telephone interviews instead would likely result in more accurate projections for the next election.

Which of the following statements, if true, would most support the argument in the passage?

A. The number of voters in Country X's next election will be significantly larger than the number of voters in the last election.

B. The Conservative Party will win the next election.

C. For each person interviewed in telephone polls before the next election, pollsters will be able to reasonably determine the likelihood of that person voting.

D. People who expressed no party preference during the in-person interviews shortly before Country X's last election did not outnumber the people who expressed a preference for the Conservative Party.

E. In the next election, pollsters will be able to conduct more in-person interviews than telephone interviews.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Pollsters, using in-person interviews shortly before the last election in Country X, incorrectly predicted that the Conservative Party would win that election, whereas the Reform Party won instead. The pollsters determined that Reform Party supporters, unlike Conservative Party supporters, are less likely to give their party preference in person than in telephone interviews.

Reasoning *What additional information, if true, would most strengthen the support, in light of the given information, for the prediction that using only telephone interviews would result in more accurate projections in the next election in Country X?* Even if in telephone interviews pollsters are more likely to get accurate information about which party a person interviewed supports, the pollsters' projections may not be accurate if the pollsters are unable to determine whether that person is actually likely to vote. So, information indicating that pollsters will be able to determine the likelihood that a person will vote would strengthen support for the conclusion.

A. If this larger number of voters in the next election is not anticipated by pollsters, then it may affect the accuracy of their predictions. However, the effect would likely be a decrease, rather than an increase, in accuracy. If the pollsters are able to accurately predict voter turnout, then their predictions for the next election could be more accurate. But we have no indication as to whether their turnout predictions will be accurate.

B. If the Conservative Party will win the next election, an underestimate of Reform Party support will be less important for the accuracy of the projection of which party will win.

C. **Correct.** It would certainly be helpful if the pollsters were able to determine how likely the person they were interviewing would be to vote.

D. This is irrelevant to the argument. The conclusion concerns the relative accuracy of telephone interviews in predicting voting numbers in the next election.

E. If pollsters are able to do more in-person interviews than telephone interviews for the next election, that at least weakly suggests that they might not be able to conduct a sufficient number of telephone interviews to get a representative sample—which would weaken support for the conclusion, not strengthen it.

The correct answer is C.

621. A company that manufactures plastic products from recyclable plastic is, surprisingly, unconcerned that economic conditions may worsen, despite analysts' belief that consumers would then consider ecofriendly plastic products an expensive luxury. But the company reasons that it will be able to lower its prices because, in

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plastic products an expensive luxury. But the company reasons that it will be able to lower its prices because, in a weakened economy, other ecofriendly plastic manufacturers are likely to fail. Demand among manufacturers for recyclable plastics as raw materials would then plummet, creating an oversupply of such materials, making them less expensive for the manufacturer to purchase and thus lowering the company's costs.

Which of the following, if true, most weakens the company's reasoning?

A. Smaller ecofriendly plastic manufacturers are more likely to fail in a weakened economy than larger ecofriendly manufacturers are.

B. Some retailers whose sales include various companies' ecofriendly plastic products have struggled in recent years despite the overall good economy.

C. Consumers would likely soon learn of the oversupply of recyclable plastics and cease recycling them, significantly raising manufacturers' raw-material costs.

D. Retailers, including retailers that cater to consumers seeking certain types of ecofriendly products, may lose some business if economic conditions worsen.

E. The plastics used by the company in its products were, after a recent investigation by a regulatory body, declared to be safe for consumers.

Argument Evaluation

Situation A company that manufactures products from recyclable plastics believes that if economic conditions worsen, it will be able to lower its prices. It believes its costs will decline because other ecofriendly plastic manufacturers will fail, thereby reducing the demand for recyclable plastics as raw materials.

Reasoning *What would most weaken the reasoning?* Suppose the company's costs did not decline and the company consequently could not reduce its prices. Even if demand for recyclable plastics as raw materials weakens in an economic downturn, the company's costs may nonetheless not decline if for some reason the supply of recyclable plastics also declines. If so, then the company may well not be able to lower its prices and stay profitable.

A. We are not told whether the company in question is a smaller ecofriendly plastic manufacturer or a larger one. Given that, the fact that smaller such companies are more likely to fail than larger ones may strengthen the argument rather than weaken it (assuming the company in question is a larger such company).

B. If some retailers whose sales include various companies' ecofriendly plastic products have struggled in a healthy economy, they may well struggle even more in a weak economy. This could help drive the company's competitors out of business, which is what the company argues is likely to happen in an economic downturn. So, rather than weakening the argument, this arguably strengthens it.

C. **Correct.** Suppose consumers learn of the oversupply of recyclable plastics and stop recycling them as a result; the oversupply may therefore not last long, and indeed a shortage might arise. This would lead not to lower raw-material costs, as the company argues, but to higher raw-material costs.

D. The information that retailers' lost business might result in a decrease in sales of the competing products does not weaken the argument. A loss of business due to worsening economic conditions is a presupposition of the argument.

E. The fact that the plastics used by the company have been declared safe has probably helped boost demand for the company's products, and perhaps for the competing products as well, yet an economic downturn could still hurt the company's competitors. So, this does little to weaken the company's argument.

The correct answer is C.

622. Researchers asked volunteers to imagine they were running a five-kilometer race against 50 people and then against 500 people, races in each of which the top 10 percent would receive a $1,000 prize. Asked about the effort they would apply in the respective cases, the volunteers indicated, on average, that they would run slower in the race against the greater number of people. A likely explanation of this result is that those of the volunteers who were most *comparatively inclined*—those who most tended to compare themselves with others in the social environment—determined (perhaps unconsciously) that extreme effort would not be worthwhile in the 500-competitor race.

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Which of the following would, if known to be true, most help justify the explanation offered above?

A. The volunteers who were most comparatively inclined were also those that had the greatest desire to win a $1,000 prize.

B. The volunteers who were the least comparatively inclined had no greater desire to win the $1,000 than those who were the most comparatively inclined.

C. The volunteers who were most comparatively inclined were likely to indicate that they would run the two races at the same speed.

D. The most comparatively inclined volunteers believed that they were significantly less likely to finish in the top 10 percent in the race against 500 than in the race against 50.

E. Volunteers were chosen for participation in the study on the basis of answers to various questions designed to measure the degree to which the volunteers were comparatively inclined.

Argument Construction

Situation Volunteers were asked how much effort they would expend when running a five-kilometer race against 50 people and how much they would expend in such a race against 500 people, when the prize for each race is $1,000 for finishing in the top 10 percent. The volunteers indicated, on average, that they would run more slowly in the race against 500 people than in the race against 50 people. This result is likely because comparatively inclined volunteers believed that extreme effort would not have been worthwhile in the race against 500 competitors.

Reasoning *What would most help to justify the explanation proposed above?* If comparatively inclined volunteers thought it was at least as likely that they would finish in the top 10 percent in the race against 500 as in the race against 50, the proposed explanation would fail. Thus, it would help justify the explanation if we knew that the comparatively inclined volunteers believed they were less likely to win in the race against 500 than in the race against 50.

A. If one knew that the volunteers who were most comparatively inclined had the greatest desire to win the $1,000, one might actually be more puzzled about why these volunteers said they would expend less effort against the 500 competitors. If they expended less effort, they would probably be less likely to finish in the top 10 percent.

B. If one knew that the volunteers who were more comparatively inclined had no less desire to win a $1,000 prize than those who were least comparatively inclined, one would have at least some reason to think the comparatively inclined volunteers wanted to win the $1,000; this clearly cannot explain why they would not expend as much effort in the 500-competitor race as in the 50-competitor race.

C. The claim that one would run the two races at the same speed contradicts the position expressed on average by the group as a whole (that they would run more slowly against the larger group of contestants). Therefore, if the most comparatively inclined volunteers said that they would run the two races at the same speed, their position would be inconsistent with that of the group as a whole. So, if this answer choice were true, it would weaken, rather than strengthen, the explanation that the views of the most comparatively inclined volunteers account for the fact that the volunteers said, on average, that they would run more slowly against the greater number of contestants.

D. **Correct.** If the most comparatively inclined volunteers believed they would be far less likely to finish in the top 10 percent in the race against 500 than in the race against 50, then they would likely believe that extreme effort would not be worthwhile in the race with more people. This therefore is likely to be at least part of the explanation.

E. Even if volunteers were chosen on the basis of answers to questions designed to measure how comparatively inclined they were, we are not told whether the volunteers were chosen because of the degree to which they were comparatively inclined.

The correct answer is D.

623.

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